



Fighting methods and weaponry
The main weapons of the Vikings were spears and axes, wielded with great force. Swords, usually the weapons of leaders, were forged by skilled smiths. They play an important part in Norse mythology. The woodcarving *(far right)* shows an episode in the story of Sigurd: the testing of the sword Gram by banging it against an anvil.

More often, however, they would simply round up the horses in the area they were attacking and appropriate them for their own purposes. Although they did not fight mounted, the Vikings used the animals to increase their speed of manoeuvre – the transition from raiding to conquest did not alter the Vikings' taste for mobility and surprise. In their campaigns in England against King Alfred of Wessex in 877–78, they used both ships and horses to move men swiftly into occupation of Anglo-Saxon territory, forcing Alfred to take refuge in impenetrable marshes without a battle fought.

BATTLE FORMATION

When the Vikings were obliged to fight a pitched battle, they formed up on foot, probably with a line of men shoulder-to-shoulder creating a shield wall, their spears bristling outward through the small openings between shield and shield. The elite warriors with their armour and heavier weaponry would stand close to their leader, whose banner would be raised behind the front line. A battle always began with an exchange of missile fire, the Viking bowmen forming an essential if rarely mentioned part of the army. Skirmishers would throw spears or small axes and there would probably be slingshots also used. At some point one or other side would mount a charge. At the battle of Edington in May 878, the Danish army of Guthrum apparently failed to break through the Anglo-Saxon shield wall and was worn down until forced to abandon the field. But if the attackers broke through, the battle would fragment into a series of fierce contests between individuals or small groups of warriors.

VIKING SETTLEMENTS

As the amount of territory controlled by the Vikings in England, Ireland, and northern France increased, many warriors were rewarded with grants of land, and raids and expeditions of conquest became less frequent. Viking men began to intermarry with women from the local population and in regions such as Normandy, central and northern England, and the area around Dublin there were extended periods of peaceful coexistence. Far off Viking colonists in Iceland faced a different problem: there was no native population and consequently a severe shortage of women. These had to be shipped in from elsewhere and a recent genetic study has shown that the female ancestors of today's Icelanders were, almost without exception, Irish.

The foundation of colonies and towns did not mean that the Vikings renounced their warlike culture. Their armies still struck terror into the neighbouring kingdoms of the Anglo-Saxons and Franks. Face to face, the Viking warrior was a formidable opponent. Vikings were generally healthy and of large stature, partly a tribute to the quality of the diet they enjoyed in their Scandinavian homeland. In combat they wielded their large swords and axes with ferocious energy that put physical strength and endurance at a premium.



Dice cup
Archaeological finds show that the Vikings had exactly the interests you would expect in a warrior race – drinking and gambling.

GOING BERSERK

The nature of Viking culture also mentally strengthened the warrior's commitment to the battle. The cult of Odin, the one-eyed god of war, stressed the importance of a warrior dying heroically in battle rather than shamefully in his bed. Odin's most enthusiastic devotees were the "berserkers". Although contested by some historians, the existence of these wild warriors is well attested in Norse literary sources. Admittedly many of these were not committed to writing until 300 years after the events they describe. Beserkers appear to have fought naked but for bear or wolf skins, working themselves into a trancelike fury before combat. Once in their inspired state, they were allegedly immune to pain and uncontrollable in their aggression. One text describes them as "mad as dogs or wolves" and "strong as bears or wild bulls". They had the strange habit of chewing the edge of their shields before battle and



Hunting, eating, and drinking
These replicas of archaeological finds show that Viking craftsmen applied decoration to everyday objects as well as to weapons and jewellery. The interlacing pattern on the leather sheath is a common motif.